Interface Analysis: HCI Inspection of Fashion Retailer Zara's Website Design

Introduction

For this report, I conducted an analysis on an interface of a specific everyday product, which is Zara's website. Due to their very questionable design choices, while also being one of the most prominent clothing companies. The method in which the website will be inspected, is through the use of Heuristic Evaluation due to the compatibility this type of evaluation has for interfaces such as websites. Although, additional evaluation techniques may be referenced when applicable.

H2-1 - Visibility of System Status (1 - Cosmetic problem)
In terms of keeping the user (myself) knowing what is actually happening, Zara's website doesn't particularly keep track of where I was within the website. Instead, the only indication is the expansion of buttons of subcategories when I pressed on a specific category (i.e. Shoes). However, the only evidence of integrated system status was while purchasing an item. Where there was a small text indication of the progress of said purchase above the transaction process.



As shown with the images above, the webpage uses text cues to inform the user, thus making both the current state and how it will progress clear to said user. Furthermore, it was included with the addition of an estimate of how long it would take, which is a brilliant method of how the user should be informed of the system status, in a particular moment. Overall, in terms where I was navigating the website, it was only a minor usability problem. Due to the very simplistic use of only text, but still has the ability of carrying out its purpose.

H2-2 - Match between system and the real world (2 - Minor usability problem)
Due to the website being very minimalistic, the website doesn't have much trouble with confusing the perception and thoughts I had on the page (when the colours are contrasting correctly). While it doesn't exactly follow real world conventions, I had to solely rely on reading through all the information in order to navigate the website. Which does work in theory, but doesn't seem very interesting to many users and can even make some lose interest or key points within the site. Overall, the match is not a significant issue with the website, but there is an obvious need for improvements (such as icons) to create more familiarity with each element/button. Hence it was only a minor usability problem.

H2-3 - User control and freedom (1 - Cosmetic problem)
In terms of user control and freedom, the I had to rely on the already installed forward and back buttons within the browser application or the navigation menu. While there is very little room for errors, the errors that were encountered tend to be very minimal, though they were inconvenient. For example, I once clicked on the wrong button in the navigation menu, which was corrected by going "back" or pressing on the intended button within the navigation menu. Which isn't a significant issue, but has significant potential to be improved. Hence it is only a cosmetic problem.

H2-4 - Consistency and standards (4 - Usability catastrophe)
While the homepage design may seem appealing in terms of the way the buttons and logo are laid out, because of the simplicity. The images tend to transition too quickly for the user to really absorb the information provided by both the images and the text. For instance, when I decided I wanted to look into what the image is promoting, the image may have already changed. Meaning that it may be too late to click on the text/image, therefore I had wait for the images to cycle through without any means of choosing the desired image indicating the promotion.

Additionally, and most concerning in design, is the fact that the menu on the very far left and very compact. Which wouldn't be as catastrophic if the buttons weren't often hard to see and read through some of background images.



As shown in the screenshot the right, the layout of the buttons are suitable. However, the colours of the buttons to the ever changing background isn't. This causes occasional task failure, delays and moderate user irritation. Which makes the positioning

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of the buttons obsolete in the first place, because the user has lost the ability to see and use them correctly. This is a significant issue because users should not have to wonder whether different words, situations or actions are visible, or if they are in different places. Overall, I believe that consistency is one of the most important aspects of any given product, and this includes the consistency of colour and images. For instance, while the logo on the interface is organized and is where it should be. The way the rest of the buttons/elements are presented, should also be consistent across the product, no matter what device is used. However, due to poor colour/image choices, it was common that the consistency was lost completely to the background. Making the user guess where the buttons were, even if the buttons were in theory laid out correctly. Hence this is a usability catastrophe.

H2-5 - Error prevention (4 - Usability catastrophe)
Through usage of Zara's website, I have noticed a lack of overall strive for creating interfaces that will prevent a problem from happening. Typically, the website should let a user know what information the user is concerned with dealing with privacy, or show the its password policy before they type it. Which I gladly found with the website. However, the problem occurred with the lack of prevention from making navigational errors, which was evident with the previous violation of the visibility issue with the navigational buttons. Hence why it is a usability catastrophe, due to the vital importance for this error prevention has on using the core aspects of the website.



H2-6 - Recognition rather than recall (2 - Minor usability problem)
In terms of recognition, Zara's website could perform better in this aspect. Due to the fact that a slight bit of learning is required to use the website, rather than recognising certain symbols to their real-life counterparts. For instance, I was initially confused by the website when first introduced to it. Through reading and exploration of the website, I learned what each button does. While some are more obvious than others, such as "Man" and "Jacket" categories. Some buttons I had difficulty understanding why they were there, such as the "Press" and "Stories" buttons. Which, in my opinion, make absolutely no sense in the aspect of the intended purpose of the website, which is purchasing clothing items. Hence this is a minor usability problem, which should be corrected nonetheless.

H2-7 - Flexibility and efficiency of use (4 - Usability catastrophe)
Due to the terrible design choice made by Zara in consideration to colours, their website design wasn't very flexible to deal with a variety of situations. Due to the fact that a variety of situations requires the user to access the navigation buttons to explore the website. While some users may be experts and know how to navigate the website without any issues, easily overcoming the barriers. Some are also novices, so they won't all have the same abilities or needs. Making them confused whenever they end up in an unfortunate situation caused by the design of the website, rather than the user itself. This prevents certain users from performing multiple tasks often. Due to this, it is a usability catastrophe.

H2-8 - Aesthetic and minimalist design (3 - Major usability problem)
The design of Zara's web page seems to be very minimalistic,"clean" and compact in design, while it may be pleasing to the eye and even works with "Fitts law", on minimal mouse movement to carry out a task. In this case it seems to be a bit too much. While it is clear the intention that Zara had with the website, it unfortunately sacrificed practicality for aesthetic and minimalist design. While the website makes the use of guidelines for the platform that they designed it for, as well as employing patterns and sticking to the said patterns of the design. This aspect is removed if the colour contrast is poor, making the layout obsolete. Consequently leaving myself and others confused, trying to find their intended link to a certain page. Which should have been spotted very quickly, if the text was clearly visible. Hence this is a major usability problem which needs to be addressed, but not a catastrophe because it already has a really good layout.

H2-9 - Helps users recognise, diagnose and recover from errors (4 - Usability catastrophe)
When using the website, I would expect the site to return an error message to me when I encounter one, that it should be expressed in plain language (meaning: no error codes/development language). For example, when I wanted to click on the basket button, in order to see my checkout but I wasn't able to access it. However, there was no error message making it increasingly difficult to detect the error I had made. Which then caused frustration with using the website due to the fact It didn't indicate the problem and explain how it can be resolved. Only later did I find out that I had to create an account in order to access the basket, which I wouldn't of known if I didn't click login and create an account. Overall, if there is no error message when an intended action doesn't occur, this can cause anxiety and creates a terrible experience. The idea is that even if an error happens, the website should make it clear what the error is and if the situation is not reversible, especially before the user performs it. Although, the user should feel that it is not catastrophic. The lack of this error message is why this is a usability catastrophe.

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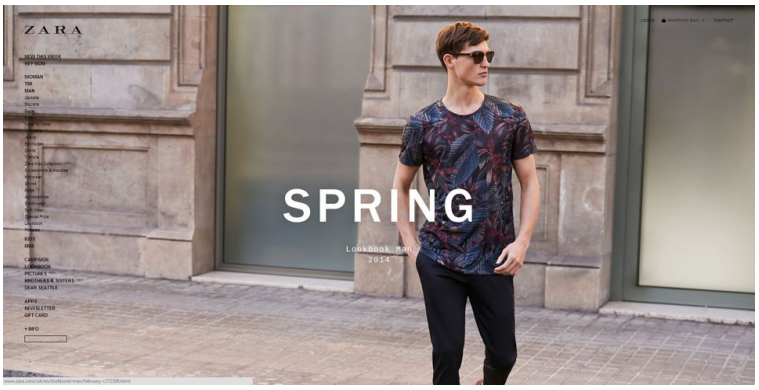
H2-10 - Help and documentation (3 - Major usability problem)
The help and documentation of the website seems to be very limited with information. While I was struggling to explore the website, due to the amount of text and bad usage of colours/images. I tried using the help “info” button to find out how to navigate the website, shown on the right. While some were understood, they were considered useless for the situation I was in. The only form of possible help was through the “Contact us” button, which was a major inconvenience. Overall, through personal experience I didn’t find the help (or “Info”) button useful in the navigation or use for the website.

Newsletter
Contact us
Stores
Buying guide
Gift Card
Gift Receipt
Press
Company

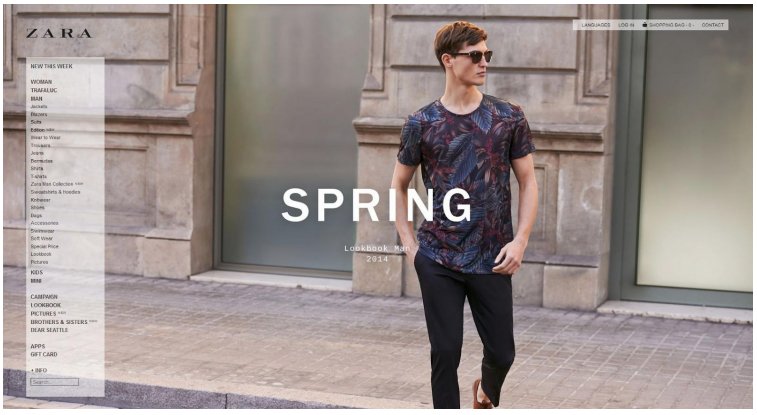
Conclusion

Problem: The vital navigational buttons and text usually blends in with the background image & lack of error recognition
Violates: “Consistency and standards” (H2-4), “Flexibility and efficiency of use” (H2-7), “Error Prevention” (H2-5) & “Help users recognize, diagnose and recover from errors” (H2-9)
Severity Rating: 4
Fix: Allow navigational text/buttons and error messages to be more distinguishable by the user

To conclude the report, their website has the capability of being an extremely well polished and layed out website, the design choices hindered the website’s design and usability a significant amount. The main catastrophic downside of the website is its use of colours and images, more specifically the poor combination of them. The style of design that the company intended for the website is highly understandable, especially for the target audience they are headed towards.



However, as shown on the image above, the execution of said design is very poor. Causing drawbacks on the user, such as the navigation through the site itself causing the user to miss key parts of the website and occasional delays. For instance, the lack of visibility for navigation bar on the top right and the navigation menu at the left hand side, when contrasted against a similar colour/contrast. Which has an effect on most the important heuristics, which are essential for a user’s need and comfort when using the webpage. Especially when dealing with errors and their recognition.



In the illustration above, it illustrates a brilliant way the navigation bar could be improved is through the introduction of a semi-transparent background behind the text, to make it significantly more readable to the user and easy to identify where the text is on the webpage. After this improvement, it is clear that the difference between the two interface designs in regards with the text, is that it contrasts between the background, making it largely unreadable. Therefore, a significant design flaw which needs to be corrected. Essentially, to sum up the main problem: In terms of usability for the average user, the website is undoubtedly fit for use by the intended target audience in theory, the problems however lies on the convenience of the use.

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